

Lankan charge: Captain Chamari Athapaththu (second from right) inspired a young Sri Lankan side to its maiden Asia Cup title two years ago, stunning India in a historic final.

India vs Pakistan rivalry is another frustrating headline clincher, handshakes or the lack of them included.

Forgotten within geopolitical rivalries and tales of Goliathan supremacy are the smaller sides for whom this tournament is a massive opportunity to take on the full members, something international cricket's class system doesn't allow as often as it should.

Slow gains

Among the associate nations, Thailand has the most experience in the ruthless waters of the Asia Cup, and has shown the most chutzpah too. It has featured five times and has even recorded victories over the likes of Sri Lanka (2018) and Pakistan (2022). The 'Smiling Assassins' topped standings in the Premier Cup and will want to make a strong impression, more so given it is drawn alongside India and Pakistan.

UAE has featured in two editions previously with just a solitary win — vs Malaysia in 2022 — to show for it. Esha Oza and Co. have consistently punched above their weight in the Asian circuit and will hope to make the most of home conditions.

Hong Kong China is back in the Asia Cup fold after 14 years and is yet to register a victory here. Joining these three sides is Indonesia, which will make its Asia Cup debut in Dubai.

The odds are stacked heavily against these teams given they are up against old powers of the Indian subcontinent. Among them, three are former champions of this tournament (only Pakistan is yet to triumph in the event).

But the gains and the success aren't democratic here. India is the runaway favourite within the fold. Political instability has denied a very sprightly Bangladesh side the kind of growth and opportunities the talents it houses deserve, but the side's bowling attack — as it always has —

continues to keep it in contention in marquee events.

Bangladesh is a side no one should take lightly in this tournament. Sri Lanka and Pakistan could take a page from the Bangla Tigers' book in breaking free from depending on a few players and moulding the team to be able to carry the side in tough games. After months of rotating labels, Pakistan has confirmed Wahab Riaz's spot in the coach's chair. The former Pakistan cricketer and selector's biggest task will be to handle Fatima Sana Khan well in the batting plans

and maximise her talents to give the side a chance to build a fighting score, particularly against India. The Lankan youngsters who teased a successful transition in 2024 now need to back words with action, with Athapaththu's move towards her career's sunset fast approaching.

Battle tested: Thailand, the most experienced associate in the Asia Cup, has featured five times and beaten Sri Lanka and Pakistan. The team will look to make an impact in a group featuring India and Pakistan.

